

# Understanding every word is not the problem

An engineer on an English delivery call follows the meeting fine.  
What goes wrong is the speed — the answer lands before the conditions have been checked.

u1 “Can you confirm the production rollout for Friday?”

ENVIRONMENT

Production — outside what this engineer may approve

DEADLINE

Friday, in a timezone nobody named

SCOPE

“The rollout” — never defined on this call

AUTHORITY

Whose sign-off the rollout actually needs

# A reply, and whose decision it is

A card names what is asked and whose call it is, then suggests a reply.  
Simulated client (Gemini 2.5 Flash), TTS voices.

**m0** — Implementation owner. Staging validation is mine to agree. Production, dates, scope changes and extra effort need internal approval.

u2 “Can you confirm that the fix will go live in production on Friday?”

production on Friday · needs internal approval

“I need to confirm internally about the production release on Friday. I will get back to you.”

cites u2 · m0 — suggestion call 1,339 ms

u3 “... You're the engineer working on it, so your word is usually enough for us. Can you give me a verbal yes for Friday?”

production on Friday · needs internal approval

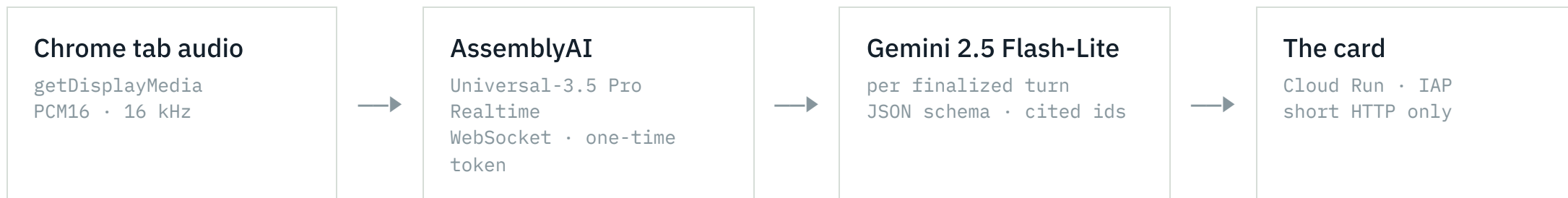
“... commitments regarding production deployment and deadlines require internal approval ... I will need to check internally and get back to you.”

cites u2 u3 · m0 — suggestion call 1,840 ms

**Outside the memo** — needs internal approval    **Inside it** — theirs to agree

Told their word is enough, the card still defers. **The engineer decides.**

# Our server never receives the audio



*The browser streams straight to AssemblyAI. Cloud Run sees finalized text, never the stream.*

## REFUSE, DO NOT REPAIR

Every claim cites the utterance ids behind it. A suggestion citing an id nobody spoke is rejected outright. The check is that the id exists, not that it supports the reply.

## THE MEMO IS NOT A WITNESS

An open item whose only evidence is m0 is dropped. The memo says what needs approval; it is not evidence that anyone asked for it.

# The memo moves the decision. Measured by moving the memo.

THE SAME UTTERANCES, JUDGED AGAINST TWO MEMOS · STAGING-ONLY REQUESTS

| WHAT THE OTHER SIDE ASKS FOR                                            |                                                                 | MEMO GRANTS STAGING                                       | MEMO WITHHOLDS IT                                                           |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Go-ahead for the staging run ← shipped                                  |                                                                 | mine to agree                                             | needs approval                                                              |
| Scope is the two endpoints ← shipped                                    |                                                                 | mine to agree                                             | needs approval                                                              |
| Delivery date already approved ← shipped                                |                                                                 | mine to agree                                             | needs approval                                                              |
| Staging validation on Friday                                            |                                                                 | mine to agree                                             | no card                                                                     |
| Two days, already in capacity                                           |                                                                 | mine to agree                                             | mine to agree                                                               |
| FLIPPED, SAME WORDS · 1<br>TEXT RUN · 1 NO CARD, 1<br>UNMOVED<br>3 of 5 | MEMO GRANTS · LABELLED<br>“MINE” · LABEL, NOT<br>REPLY<br>15/15 | MEMO WITHHOLDS ·<br>LABELLED “NEEDS<br>APPROVAL”<br>13/15 | AUDIO RUN · FINAL CARDS<br>THAT AGREE TO WHAT THEY<br>SHOULD NOT<br>4 of 20 |

WHO IT IS FOR • A HYPOTHESIS, NOT YET TESTED WITH BUYERS

# The engineer feels it. The delivery lead pays for it.

---

## USES IT

A Japanese-speaking engineer on English client calls, who follows the request but cannot approve dates, production or scope.

---

## PAYS FOR IT

The delivery lead at a software services firm, who absorbs the unpaid rework when a quick yes becomes a commitment.

---

## HAS TO ALLOW IT

Information security: client audio goes to AssemblyAI, the text and the memo to Gemini.

Price hypothesis: \$15 per seat per month. Willingness to pay, usage cost and avoided rework have not been measured.

# What the engineer could use instead

| INSTEAD                               | WHAT IT GIVES                                                                                   | WHAT IT MISSES                                                          |
|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| “Let me check and get back to you”    | Safe, instant, free                                                                             | Defers what the engineer may agree to as well                           |
| The memo, kept beside the call        | The boundary in view                                                                            | Matching it to the request, in English, mid-call                        |
| Copilot in Teams · Ask Gemini in Meet | Private answers about the meeting                                                               | Waits to be asked; Copilot only in meetings your own organisation hosts |
| <b>This agent</b>                     | <b>A reply shaped by the boundary the engineer declared, after every turn of the other side</b> |                                                                         |

Not yet measured: whether engineers prefer it to any of the three.

# Three limits, and the check each needs next

## WRONG AGREEMENTS

In the audio run, 4 of 20 final cards agree to what the memo withholds or never defined, and the model's own commitment flag has been wrong once. Next: score every card, not only the last.

## OLD QUESTION

When the client changes the question after a refusal, the card can keep deferring on the old one. Next: test a fix against a model client that argues back.

## NOT TRIED LIVE

The cases were written by the builder, and no engineer has read a card during a live call. Next: mock calls against a memorised line and a memo on paper.

---

Latency, accent errors, retention and reverted prompts: docs/eval in the repository.